Kennedy announced the blockade in his speech of 22 October and signed the proclamation in a formal White House ceremony on 23 October. On the evening of 23 October, however, ExComm was still debating how operations were to be run. The President was anxious about his ability to exercise control and despatched Robert McNamara to the Pentagon to review the navy's plans. As Martin Sherwin explains, the Defense Secretary arrived there at 10.00pm after a gruelling day during a gruelling week. By now he was sleeping in his office and unquestionably under considerable stress. Accounts differ over his exchange with the Chief of Naval Operations, Admiral George Anderson, concerning the management of the operation. A highly influential narrative emerged that epitomised the lessons that JFK had taken from Barbara Tuchman. An important source of that narrative has been Robert McNamara.

At the first of the 'critical oral history' conferences in 1987, McNamara recounted his exchange with Admiral Anderson on the evening of 23 October.[80] The location of every Soviet ship approaching the quarantine line had been pinpointed, and it was expected that one would reach the blockade line the next day. The Defense Secretary asked Admiral Anderson how he would stop it. 'We'll hail it', the admiral replied. McNamara wanted to know whether this would be in English or Russian. 'How the hell do I know?' was Anderson's response (according to McNamara, who added that he was 'clearly, a little agitated by my line of questioning'). When asked what would happen if the captains did not understand, Anderson said 'I suppose we'll use flags' (according to McNamara). When asked what would happen if they did not stop, Anderson explained that a shot would be fired across their bow. McNamara then asked:

'Well, what if that doesn't work?'

'Then we'll fire into the rudder' [Anderson] replied, by now, clearly very annoyed.

'What kind of ship is it?' I asked.

'A tanker, Mr Secretary.' he said.

'You're not going to fire a single shot at anything without my express permission. Is that clear? I said. That's when he made his famous remark